

Workbook

Secondary · Supporting your Autistic young person to flourish

This workbook is yours. It holds a short summary of each session and space to write your own thoughts about your young person. Nothing in it needs to be shared.

Name (optional)

STATEMENT OF RECONCILIATION

We at Positive Partnerships value and recognise the diversity of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures and heritage and their proud part in Australia's national identity. We acknowledge and continue to learn about Australia's colonial past and the historic and ongoing impacts on Australia's First Nations people. We believe in and strongly support the Truth-telling of Australia's colonial history and in moving forward as a nation we must encourage open, honest dialogue and build relationships built on respect and trust.

Welcome

You are the expert on your young person. Today builds on what you already know with shared language, useful ideas and practical tools, and time to talk with other families.

How to use this workbook

- Each session starts with a short summary of the key ideas.
- Activity pages follow. Write as much or as little as you like.
- You can pass on any activity. Move, stretch or step out whenever you need to.
- Keep other families' stories in the room.

The day at a glance

Time	Session	
9:30 - 10:15	1	Supporting your Autistic young person to flourish
10:15 - 11:00	2	Understanding Autistic Experience: sensory and thinking
11:00 - 11:15		<i>Morning tea</i>
11:15 - 12:15	3	Communication, Connection and Managing Daily Capacity
12:15 - 12:45		<i>Lunch</i>
12:45 - 1:30	4	Home and Community
1:30 - 2:10	5	Partnership with the School
2:10 - 2:30	6	Full Circle

Supporting your Autistic young person to flourish

Key ideas

Neurodiversity

Neurodiversity is the whole picture. Neurotypical and neurodivergent describe brain patterns within it. Autism is one expression of that diversity: a different way of experiencing and processing the world, not something to fix.

A neurodiversity-affirming approach

- Acknowledging different ways of knowing, doing, being and belonging
- All people have strengths and experience challenges
- Differences are not deficits
- There is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave
- Everyone experiences and interacts with the world differently

Intersectionality

People have many different parts to their identity. When these overlap, they can affect the opportunities, support, barriers and experiences a person has in life.

Dynamic disability

Your young person's capacity can change from minute to minute, day to day and term to term. Same young person, different capacity.

Joy and flourishing

Joy, connection and belonging matter. Small moments and successes can matter as much as big ones. Flourishing looks different for every family.

ACTIVITY**One thing I would like to know today** Introductions

ACTIVITY**What I love and value about my young person** On your own

Three things that make them who they are: strengths, joys, interests, connections. Just who they are, not needs or challenges. You will come back to this at the end of the day.

1	2	3

ACTIVITY**Young people's voices** After the video

What stayed with you?	What would you like to understand more deeply about your young person?

Understanding Autistic Experience

Sensory and Thinking

Key ideas

Sensory processing

Sensory processing is the way the brain receives, processes and responds to information from the senses. There are eight senses: touch, vision, taste, hearing and smell, plus proprioception (body in space), vestibular (balance and movement) and interoception (internal body signals). Sensory experience can bring joy as well as overwhelm.

Winnie Dunn describes four sensory profiles: registration, seeking, sensitive and avoiding. A person can show different patterns for different senses, and patterns shift with the day.

Stimming and authentic expression

Stimming is repetitive movement or sound, like pacing, tapping, fidgeting or humming. It can help your young person regulate, focus, cope or show joy. It is authentic expression and often a sign of regulation, not something to stop by default. Notice what it does for them, make space for it (fidget tools and music can help), respect their privacy, only redirect if it causes harm, and help others understand. Many teens hide their stims at school, so home can be a place where they do not need to.

Autistic thinking

- Detail-first brain: noticing details first and building the bigger picture from them.
- Deep focus brain: attention goes deeply into fewer things. Switching focus can take time and warning.
- Executive functioning: planning, organisation, time management, working memory, meta-cognition, emotional regulation, flexibility, attention, task initiation and persistence.

Internal signals

Interoception is understanding the body's internal signals, like hunger, thirst or needing the bathroom. Alexithymia is difficulty identifying and describing emotions. Sometimes a build-up happens inside before anything shows on the surface.

Choose one familiar routine at home. What sensory demands does it create, and what could make it easier or give more choice?

Routine:

Sensory demand	What could make it easier, or give more choice	Question to explore with my young person
1		
2		
3		

ACTIVITY**Thinking discussion** Small groups

What are your young person's deep interests?

What do you notice when they are fully engaged with these interests?

When does your young person have trouble getting started or shifting their attention?

Have you seen them fully absorbed in something at home? What were they doing?

ACTIVITY**Reading the signs** Small groups

What signs and changes do you notice before your young person becomes overwhelmed?

What would be useful for others to know about these signs?

Understanding Autistic Experience

Communication, Connection and Managing Daily Capacity

Key ideas

Communication

Speech is one part of communication. How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand. Clear communication, processing time and visual supports all help, and the right support depends on the person and the moment.

Double empathy and connection

Misunderstanding can happen in both directions between people who communicate differently. Connection does not need to look one way: it can happen with family, at school, in the community and online.

Managing daily capacity

Think of your young person's energy as a battery. Every day starts with a different charge, every action uses some, and capacity changes from day to day.

Masking in the teenage years

The pressure to fit in is often highest in the secondary years, and masking often increases. Burnout and School Can't can build up over time. It is also a time of growth: young people can build self-understanding and self-advocacy when they feel safe.

Masking and positive Autistic identity

Some Autistic people work hard to appear "fine", and that has a cost. A young person who knows who they are, and feels genuinely valued for it, has more available for everything else.

ACTIVITY**Who is part of the communication network?** On your own

Put your young person in the centre. Add the people and places in their world.

Home family, carers, pets	Friends in person or online	School teachers, classmates
Community sport, clubs, shops	Young person	Supports therapists, tools

ACTIVITY**What should travel between people and places?** On your own

A communication strength	What helps communication	What I would like others to know

ACTIVITY**Connection discussion** Small groups

When does your young person seem most comfortable connecting with others?

What kinds of connection do they enjoy? (Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)

Are there times when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?

What can adults do to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?

ACTIVITY**Masking discussion** Small groups

When does your young person seem to be working hard to appear "fine" when they are not?

When and where do they seem most comfortable being themselves?

What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Home and Community

Key ideas

Distress and overwhelm

Behaviour is communication. What we see is often the tip of the iceberg; underneath sit thoughts, feelings and needs. Shutdown and meltdown are involuntary responses to overwhelm, not a choice. Autistic burnout and School Can't are often signs that a young person has been coping with more than we realised, for longer than we realised.

Co-regulation first

A calm, trusted adult helps your young person settle. Self-regulation grows over time, with support. In the moment: be curious, reduce input, use a safe space, and save the talking for later.

Home and family life

- Recovery time after school: food, quiet, movement or screen, their choice, before questions or homework.
- Homework and assessment: help with the start, make the timeline visible, break it down, and talk to school if the load is too much.
- Interests are an anchor for regulation, connection, joy and identity.
- Growing independence: small steps, risk talked about together, and home as a safe base.
- Sleep and screens: work out honest trade-offs together and review them.
- Your own battery counts. Small, daily things help.

ACTIVITY**My young person's signs and what helps** On your own

Early signs I notice	What helps in the moment	What helps them recover

ACTIVITY**One step towards independence** Table groups

The skill or task:

The first small step	Support that stays in place	How we will review it together

ACTIVITY**What works in our home** Let's share what works

Mornings, after school, homework, sleep, screens, or your own battery.

Something that works for us	An idea from another family I would like to try

ACTIVITY**My own battery** On your own

Small things that recharge me	Who I can ask for help

Partnership with the School

Key ideas

Working in partnership

Families, school staff and support staff each bring different knowledge and a different relationship with your young person. Your young person is at the centre of every partnership.

Effective collaboration

Shared goals · shared values · mutual trust and respect · consulting on decisions · seeing other perspectives · curiosity · your young person's voice · assuming good intent.

Your rights at school

The Disability Discrimination Act 1992 makes it unlawful to treat someone unfairly because of disability, including in education. Under the Disability Standards for Education 2005, schools must consult your young person, or you on their behalf, about reasonable adjustments.

What you can ask: How will we be consulted? What adjustments are in place? How and when will they be reviewed?

Power dynamics

Power can sit in socio-economic status, experiences of education, language, understanding of school systems, and in how meetings are run. Naming it helps.

Young people in their own meetings

Move from talking about your young person to having them take part and, over time, lead. Speaking up for themselves now is practice for senior school, work and life after school.

Transition planning starts early

Subject choices and pathways in the middle years shape what comes next. Include your young person, and ask careers staff and learning support who can help.

Consultation

Useful consultation has a clear shared purpose, open questions, more than one way to contribute, respect for your knowledge, accurate records and an agreed action with follow-up.

ACTIVITY**Power dynamics** Sticky notes

An imbalance from a home perspective	An imbalance from a school perspective	How these imbalances could be addressed

ACTIVITY**Student voice** After the video

What decisions were made, and who made them?	What impact did those decisions have on Adon?	How is my young person asked and heard at school?

ACTIVITY**Who to contact for what** On your own

	Name or role	How to reach them
Day to day		
Learning and adjustments		
Wellbeing		
My main contact		

ACTIVITY**Consultation checklist** For your next meeting

- ☐ A clear, shared purpose
- ☐ Open questions
- ☐ More than one way to contribute
- ☐ Respect for my knowledge and my young person's
- ☐ Accurate recording of what was heard
- ☐ An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

What needs to be understood?

What question will open the conversation?

How will my young person's voice be included?

What can be decided together?

How and when will we follow up?

Key ideas

- Belonging: being recognised, included and able to participate as oneself.
- Capacity: what the day costs, protects and restores.
- Joy: interests, connection and authentic expression.

ACTIVITY**Three small things** Bringing it all together**One thing to try at home this week**

Keep it small.

One thing I would like school to know, understand or support

And the sentence I will open with.

One strength I see in my young person

And when I will tell them this week. Look back at page 4.

Connections that continue

Today is a starting point. These supports continue after the workshop.

Other families	The families in this room, parent groups, local and online.
Webinars and deep dives	Titles and dates to confirm
Online Community of Practice	Link and QR code TBA
Positive Partnerships	positivepartnerships.com.au
NCCD Meetings Tool Kit	Help to prepare for meetings about adjustments: https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit
Disability Standards for Education	Getting started; Advocating with and for your child; Milestones and transitions (Department of Education): education.gov.au/disability-standards-education-2005
Autism Connect	National autism helpline: 1300 308 699
Disability Gateway	1800 643 787
Carer Gateway	Emotional, practical and financial support for carers: 1800 422 737
Kids Helpline	Free, private counselling for young people aged 5 to 25, and for parents: 1800 55 1800
headspace	Mental health support for young people aged 12 to 25: headspace.org.au
Lifeline	Crisis support, 24 hours: 13 11 14

My notes
